

Heavyweight clash

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European giants serve up another chapter of **high-octane** drama in the Champions League.

Joan Mathew Jacob

joan.mathew@thehindu.co.in

Real Madrid versus Manchester City is now a European clash settled into familiarity.

Since their first meeting in the 2012-13 season, the teams had played each other 14 more times before being pitted against one another again on matchday six of the ongoing league stage.

Los Blancos had blanked City in the play-offs last season, but this time they came out severely depleted, with injuries to several defenders and, more starkly, to UEFA Champions League Golden Boot leader Kylian Mbappe. Despite the disadvantages, it was Madrid that set the ball rolling. After knocking on City's door a couple of times, Rodrygo ended his nine-month scoring drought with a pacy run and a precise finish past Gianluigi Donnarumma.

City immediately switched on and piled on the pressure before restoring parity eight minutes later.

A stroke of luck helped Nico O'Reilly

grab his first Champions League goal, with Thibaut Courtois spilling Josko Gvardiol's header into the left-back's path in front of goal, an opportunity he made good use of.

Five minutes later, Antonio Rudiger pulled down Erling Haaland (**above**) inside the box, allowing the Norwegian to slot in his sixth goal of the campaign. With the win, City moved back into the top eight and into fourth with 13 points and two matches left in the league phase, while Madrid sits seventh with 12.

Meanwhile, Arsenal maintained its 100 per cent record after an easy outing at Club Brugge, where Noni Madueke grabbed a brace, while Gabriel Martinelli kept alive his five-match scoring streak in the competition.

However, its city rival Chelsea fared poorly against Atalanta, giving up a one-goal lead to lose 1-2, with Charles De Ketelaere grabbing an assist before scoring the winner.

Spanish leader Barcelona banished the ghosts of its 2021-22 Europa League quarterfinal defeat to Eintracht Frankfurt as the two sides met in the

top tier for the first time. The Germans took the lead through Ansgar Knauff, but a quickfire header brace from Jules Kounde in the second half ensured the Catalans came away with all three points.

Meanwhile, amid a chaotic week in Merseyside following Mohamed Salah's scathing comments, Arne Slot brought Liverpool back to winning ways with a narrow victory against Italian giant Inter Milan. It took 88 minutes and a penalty to find a winner, with Dominik Szoboszlai converting from the spot after Alessandro Bastoni committed a foul.

The result leaves Liverpool just outside the automatic knockout qualification spots in ninth with 12 points, level with Atletico Madrid (eighth), Madrid (seventh) and Inter (sixth). Bayern Munich occupies second place with 15 points after a routine 3-1 win against Sporting CP, while PSG, Manchester City and Atalanta follow with 13 each.

At the foot of the table sit Kairat Almaty and Villarreal, both with just a solitary point so far.